

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 3

Chocolate

"The Food of the Gods"

Geography

Teacher Curriculum Packet

Pilot Edition | 2026-2027

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it has generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You don't need to play the full episode. CUT-3D is the Economics segment; CUT-3E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC covering 21 episodes:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.
- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 3 Overview: Chocolate

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Food of the Gods
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-3A	Cold Open: The Price of Gods	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-3B	The Cacao Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-3C	From Sacred Drink to Slave Trade	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-3D	The \$161 Billion Bar	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-3E	The Gods Write Back	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-3F	The Conscious Bar (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 3 follows cacao from Mayan ceremonial centers in Mesoamerica, where it was currency and sacred drink, through the colonial plantation economy that moved production to West Africa, to a \$161.5 billion global industry where Ivory Coast farmers earn less than \$1 per day. The episode asks why the people who grow chocolate have never tasted it.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. Episode 3 connects directly to Episode 1 (Coffee) and Episode 4 (Sugar) as part of a three-episode arc on colonial commodities.

Geography Vocabulary

Introduce these terms before the Geography segment (CUT-3B, starting at 2:00).

Term	Pronunciation	Definition
Cacao	kah-KOW	The tree and seeds that are processed into chocolate. Not the same as cocoa, which is the processed product.
Theobroma cacao	thee-oh-BROH-mah kah-KOW	The scientific name for the cacao tree. Theobroma means 'food of the gods' in Greek.
Cacao Belt	kah-KOW BELT	The tropical band between 20 degrees N and 20 degrees S latitude where cacao can grow. Narrower than the Coffee Belt (25N to 30S).
Canopy shade	KAN-oh-pee SHAYD	The tree cover that cacao needs to survive. It can't grow in direct tropical sun, linking its survival to forest ecosystems.
Monoculture	MON-oh-kul-cher	Growing only one crop on a large area. West African cacao is largely monoculture, making it vulnerable to disease and climate shifts.
Commodity processing	kuh-MOD-ih-tee PROSS-es-ing	Transforming a raw material into a finished product. 85 percent of chocolate processing happens in Europe and North America, not in producing countries.

Climate refuge	KLY-met REF-yooj	A geographic area that stays suitable for a crop as climate change reduces overall suitable land. Ecuador and Peru may serve as cacao climate refuges.
Geographic injustice	jee-oh-GRAF-ik in-JUS-tis	When the geographic locations that bear a commodity's environmental and labor costs aren't the same as those that capture its economic value.
Supply chain geography	SUH-ply CHAYN jee-OG-ruh-fee	The physical geography of how a commodity moves from farm to consumer, including which countries add value at each stage.
Value-added processing	VAL-yoo AD-ed PROSS-es-ing	Steps that transform raw materials and increase their economic value. Roasting, grinding, conching, and molding are chocolate's value-added stages.

Geography Data Sheet: The Cacao Belt

Climate Requirements for Cacao

Factor	Cacao Requirement	Why It Matters
Latitude range	20 degrees N to 20 degrees S	The narrowest belt of any major food commodity. Coffee grows from 25N to 30S; cacao is even more restricted.
Temperature	65 to 90 degrees F (18 to 32 degrees C)	Frost kills cacao. Too much heat during flowering reduces yield significantly.
Annual rainfall	1,500 to 2,500 mm	Needs consistent moisture. Both drought and flooding threaten the crop.
Elevation	0 to 1,000 feet (0 to 300 m)	Unlike coffee (which prefers altitude), cacao grows best at low elevation in tropical zones.
Shade requirement	Partial shade required	Cacao can't survive full tropical sun. It needs a forest canopy, linking its survival to deforestation rates.
Soil	Deep, well-drained, slightly acidic	Rich organic matter from a forest floor is essential for natural cacao cultivation.
Dry season	1 to 2 months preferred	A short dry season triggers flowering. Too long a dry season reduces production.

Top Cacao-Producing Countries (2024)

Rank	Country	Annual Production	Pct Global Total	Farmer Daily Income
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1	Cote d'Ivoire (Ivory Coast)	2,180,000 tonnes	42%	\$0.50 to \$0.84/day
2	Ghana	883,000 tonnes	17%	\$0.45 to \$0.78/day
3	Indonesia	659,000 tonnes	13%	\$1.25 to \$2.00/day
4	Nigeria	340,000 tonnes	6.5%	\$0.35 to \$0.65/day
5	Ecuador	285,000 tonnes	5.5%	\$1.50 to \$3.00/day
6	Brazil	235,000 tonnes	4.5%	\$2.00 to \$4.00/day
7	Cameroon	180,000 tonnes	3.5%	\$0.40 to \$0.70/day
8	Peru	160,000 tonnes	3%	\$1.75 to \$3.25/day

The Geographic Injustice: Who Grows vs. Who Profits

Region	Cultural Connection	Production Share	Processing Share	Farmer Income
Mesoamerica (Mexico, Guatemala)	Cacao's origin. 3,000+ years of use.	1.5% (Mexico)	Under 1%	\$2 to \$5/day (small farms)
West Africa (Ivory Coast, Ghana)	No pre-colonial cacao tradition	59% of global supply	Under 5%	\$0.45 to \$0.84/day
Europe (Belgium, Switzerland, Germany)	No growing capacity	0%	Over 50%	Factory workers: \$80 to \$200/day
North America	No growing capacity	0%	Over 30%	Factory workers: \$100 to \$250/day

Cacao originated in Mesoamerica and was cultivated for over 3,000 years before European contact. Today, Mesoamerica grows a tiny fraction of global supply.

West Africa, which had no indigenous cacao tradition, grows 59 percent of the world's cacao, with the lowest-paid farmers in the entire supply chain.

Indiana connection: Indiana sits far outside the Cacao Belt at roughly 40 degrees N latitude. No commercial cacao grows here. But the average Indianapolis resident consumes roughly 11 pounds of chocolate per year, connecting every household to the geography of West African production and a \$161 billion global industry.

Climate Change Threat to Cacao

Region	Current Status	2050 Projection	Primary Threat
West Africa (Ivory Coast, Ghana)	59% of global production	Up to 89% loss of suitable land in some projections	Rising temps exceed 90 degree F threshold; reduced rainfall
Indonesia	13% of production	Significant reduction projected	Increased flooding; temperature stress
Ecuador and Peru highlands	8.5% combined	May expand as lowlands become too hot	Potential climate refuge; infrastructure currently limited
Brazil (Bahia state)	4.5%	Moderate reduction	Increased drought frequency

Geography Activity: The Cacao Belt vs. The Chocolate Belt

Time: 35 to 40 minutes. Materials: this packet plus a world map or Google Earth.

The Core Geographic Paradox

There's a Cacao Belt (where cacao grows) and a Chocolate Belt (where chocolate is processed, branded, and consumed). They're on opposite sides of the world. Students map both.

Step 1: Map the Two Belts (10 minutes)

- Draw the Cacao Belt between 20 degrees N and 20 degrees S. Shade the top five producers.
- Mark Mesoamerica (cacao's origin: Mexico and Guatemala) with a different color or symbol.
- Mark major chocolate processing countries: Belgium, Switzerland, Germany, USA.
- Draw arrows showing the physical flow of cacao from production to processing countries.

Step 2: Geographic Questions (15 minutes)

- Ivory Coast farmers earn \$0.50 to \$0.84 per day. Belgian factory workers earn roughly \$80 to \$200. Both are doing work that wouldn't exist without the other. What geographic and economic factors explain this gap?
- Cacao originated in Mesoamerica. Mexico today produces only 1.5 percent of global cacao. Ivory Coast, with no indigenous cacao tradition, produces 42 percent. What historical events caused this geographic shift?
- Climate change could eliminate up to 89 percent of Ivory Coast's suitable cacao land by 2050. What would a geographic shift in cacao production mean for the communities that currently grow it?

Step 3: Comparing Belts (10 minutes)

- Which belt is narrower: Coffee (25N to 30S) or Cacao (20N to 20S)? Why does this matter for supply security?
- Both coffee and cacao need shade or specific forest conditions. How does this link both commodities to deforestation rates?
- Processing for both coffee and chocolate happens overwhelmingly in consuming countries. What would need to change for this to shift?

Discussion Questions

- Is it geographically inevitable that cacao producers earn less than chocolate processors? Or is this a policy choice that geography makes easy to avoid addressing?
- If the Cacao Belt shifts significantly by 2050, who should be responsible for supporting the communities that lose their primary livelihood?

Geography Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. Define the Cacao Belt and explain why it's narrower than the Coffee Belt. What climate requirement is most responsible for cacao's restricted growing range?

2. 85 percent of chocolate processing happens in Europe and North America, not in the countries that grow cacao. Using geographic and economic reasoning, explain why this is the case and what it means for value distribution in the supply chain.

3. Climate change threatens to eliminate up to 89 percent of suitable cacao land in West Africa by 2050. Explain: (a) why this is happening, (b) what geographic options cacao farmers have, and (c) what limits those options.

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Cacao Belt: 20N to 20S. Coffee Belt: 25N to 30S. Cacao is more restricted. The most limiting factor is the shade dependency: cacao can't survive in full tropical sun and needs a forest canopy, limiting it to ecosystems where that canopy exists and is maintained. This is more restrictive than coffee's temperature and elevation requirements.

Q2 expected answer:

Processing happens in consuming countries because: (1) colonial trade structures shipped raw materials to Europe for value-added processing; (2) industrial processing requires infrastructure investment that European corporations funded; (3) trade tariffs historically penalized processed goods from producing countries more than raw commodities. This keeps the majority of economic value, jobs, and tax revenue in Europe and North America rather than in Ivory Coast or Ghana.

Q3 expected answer:

(a) Rising temperatures will exceed the 90 degree F threshold cacao can tolerate, and rainfall patterns are becoming unreliable. (b) Options include moving to higher elevations (limited in flat West Africa), switching to more heat-tolerant varieties, increasing shade cover. (c) Limits: West Africa lacks the mountain terrain for altitude refuge; new varieties take years to establish; shade planting reduces land for other crops. Ecuador and Peru may become more suitable, but the social and economic infrastructure to shift production there doesn't exist yet.

Indiana Geography Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
WG.1.1	Use geographic tools to analyze spatial patterns	Cacao Belt and Chocolate Belt mapping; production flow arrows
WG.1.3	Analyze distributions using geographic data	Production by country table; geographic injustice table
WG.3.1	Analyze characteristics of climate zones	Cacao climate requirements; comparison to coffee belt
WG.3.2	Evaluate how physical systems affect human activity	Shade dependency linking cacao to deforestation; climate change and livelihoods
WG.5.1	Analyze how human activity modifies the physical environment	Deforestation for cacao monoculture; forest canopy loss
WG.5.3	Evaluate consequences of human-environment interaction	Climate change reducing suitable land; geographic justice questions

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or what helped?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged.) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next year:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club